

ACTIVITY 4 — LEARNER WORKSHEET**Improve — Choose and Pilot a Countermeasure**

TYPE	DURATION	MAPS TO	TOPIC
Hands-on Lab	30 minutes	IMPROVE	Improve — Fix the Cause

Name	
Date	

What you are doing

The team has proved its root cause and has a week to try something. The owner has agreed to a pilot but has made clear there is no budget for equipment this quarter.

What you will produce: A brainstormed countermeasure list, a completed impact/effort grid with one countermeasure selected, standard work for the new method, and a one-week pilot plan naming a measure, an owner and a review date.

The scenario

Twelve countermeasures were generated at the last team meeting, ranging from adding the counter milk restock to the opening checklist through to installing a mobile pre-order app. They vary enormously in cost, effort and risk, and the team has limited time and no capital.

A cause is only worth finding if something changes because of it. Your job is to choose one countermeasure small enough to try next week, write the new method down so anyone on shift could follow it, and plan how you will know whether it worked.

Your steps

1. **Restate the root cause** — Write your top root cause from Lab 3 at the top of templates/countermeasure-brainstorm-template.csv. Every idea from here on must address THIS cause. The discipline of Improve is solving the cause you proved, not the symptom you started with.
2. **Brainstorm without judging** — Generate at least six countermeasures without evaluating any of them yet. Then compare your list with data/countermeasure-options.csv, which holds the twelve the team generated, with impact, effort, cost and risk already scored.
3. **Check the Lean tools** — Two quick tests. 5S: is anything at the counter hard to find, out of place or untidy? Mistake proofing (Poka-Yoke): could the wrong order be made impossible rather than merely discouraged? Both often produce cheaper fixes than adding people.
4. **Plot the impact/effort grid** — Using the Impact and Effort scores in the data, plot every idea on templates/impact-effort-grid-template.csv and pick ONE from the high-impact, low-effort corner. Force a spread when scoring — if everything is high impact, the grid tells you nothing.

5. **Write the standard work** — In templates/standard-work-and-pilot-template.csv, write the improved method as short numbered steps anyone on shift could follow, ending in an unambiguous done/not-done check. If you write 'make sure there is enough milk', ask how the next person would know.
6. **Write the pilot plan** — Complete the pilot rows: what changes, who runs it, the start and end dates, what you will measure, the baseline to beat, how you will know it worked, and the review date. Pilot ONE countermeasure — change two and you will not know which one worked.
7. **Compare against what actually happened** — Now open data/pilot-week-results.csv and read the week day by day against your plan. Pay close attention to Thursday. Ask yourselves what Thursday tells you about the countermeasure — and about what is still missing.

Your working space

Complete every field. You may keep this worksheet and refer to it during the open-book assessment.

Step 1 — Restate the root cause

Step 2 — Brainstorm without judging

Step 3 — Check the Lean tools

Step 4 — Plot the impact/effort grid

Step 5 — Write the standard work

Step 6 — Write the pilot plan

Step 7 — Compare against what actually happened

Answers to the discussion prompts

1. Which countermeasures address the proven root cause, and which quietly address the symptom instead?

2. What does the impact/effort grid tell you that a simple list of ideas does not?

3. Why pilot only ONE countermeasure rather than several at once?

4. Looking at the pilot week results — what happened on Thursday, and what does it reveal?

Reflect & discuss

Was your instinct to pick the most impressive solution or the most effective one?

Would your standard work be followable by someone on their first day, with no explanation?

The pilot worked on four days of five. Is that a success or a failure, and why?

Check your work

Every group can show a countermeasure that addresses the Lab 3 root cause, a completed impact/effort grid with one selection, numbered standard work with a done/not-done check, and a pilot plan naming a measure, an owner and a review date.